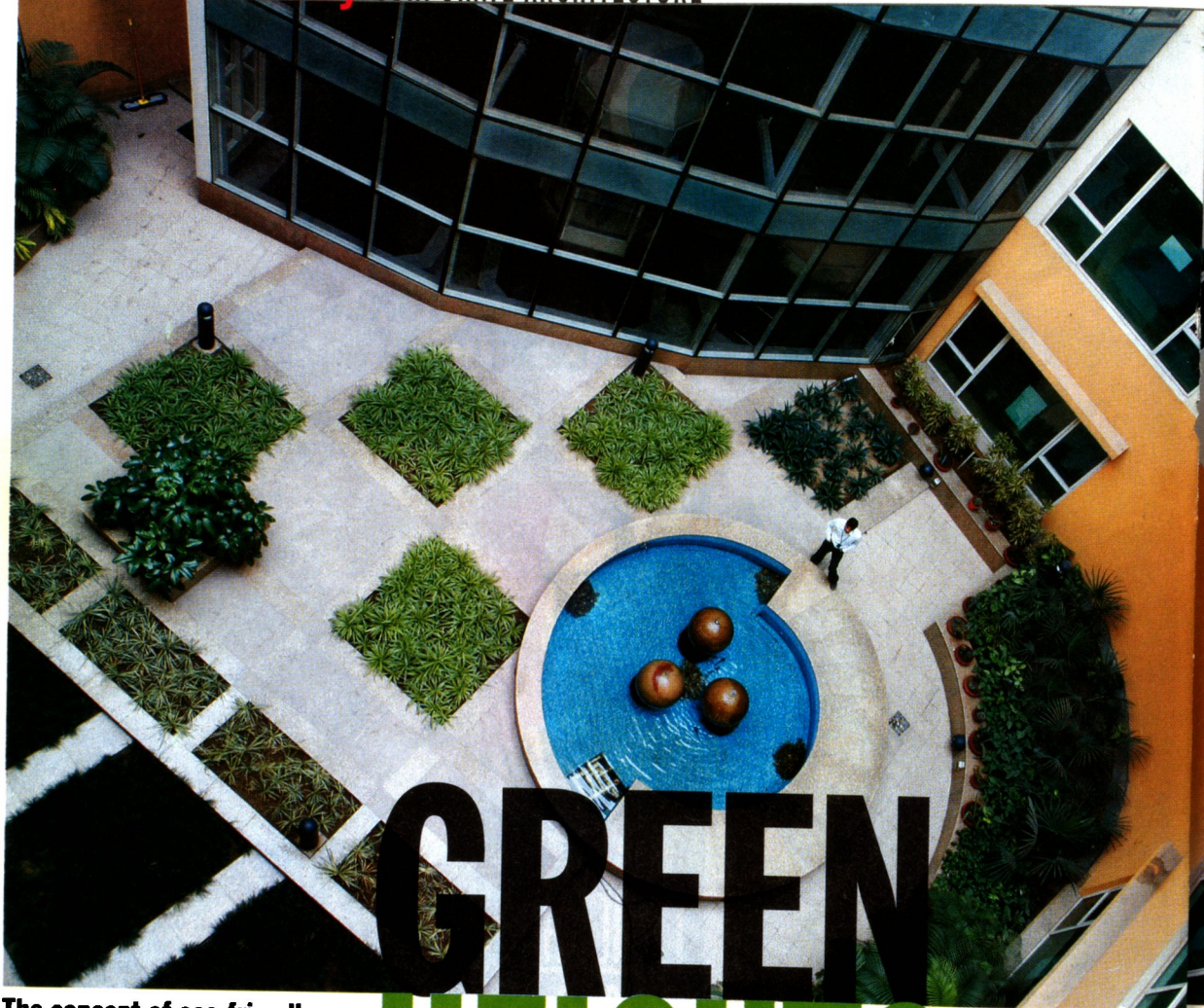




GREEN HEIGHTS

The concept of eco-friendly buildings is fast catching up in India. They are healthier and improve productivity apart from saving money and energy.

■ By Nandini Vaish

When architect Vidur Bhardwaj was designing the Wipro Technologies Centre in Gurgaon, he was "putting in what others were throwing." Quite unlike the usual buildings that dot Gurgaon's skyline, Wipro's office is made up of recycled material. The door frames are made up of wood stripped from an old ship in Jamnagar, while the staircase railings came from a flea market. The courtyard is inspired by the traditional *haveli* design that not only

allows light, but also keeps the walls cool. A water body and vegetation in the centre allow evaporative cooling; the building's insulated rooftops and terrace gardens reduce the solar heat. Inside, sensors have been fitted to detect the number of people present in the rooms and cool them accordingly.

The Wipro centre has been rated as one of Asia's most energy-efficient office buildings by US-based Green Building Council and has scored a platinum rating under the Leadership in Energy & Environmental Design (LEED) rating system for meeting environmen-

tal standards. Most importantly, it has enabled the company save Rs 1 crore in power costs annually or 55 per cent of its energy consumption. The extra cost of construction—six to eight per cent over a normal building—will be recovered in five years.

Green or sustainable architecture is catching on. It employs concepts of energy efficiency, water conservation, minimal disturbance to surroundings and use of eco-friendly materials. "A green building is like a tree. It produces its own energy, holds its own water, sequesters carbon and provides habitat